Sales vs Supply Chain: How to Handle Stock Shortages in Business English

Situation: Liam, a Key Account Manager at a beverage manufacturer, meets Rachel, Head of Supply Chain Planning, in her office. Liam has just confirmed an extra thirty-percent volume for a nationwide supermarket promotion starting in ten days, but production is already fully booked.
Liam — Key Account Manager · **Rachel** — Head of Supply Chain Planning

Transcript

Rachel: Liam, do you have a few minutes to talk about Retail Mart?
Liam: Yes, of course. Is there an issue with their summer promo order?
Rachel: A big issue. You confirmed thirty thousand extra cases this morning.
Liam: Yes, they agreed to a massive nationwide summer campaign on iced tea.
Rachel: But you never checked with supply chain before sending that confirmation.
Liam: The buyer needed an immediate answer, or they would call our competitor.
Rachel: **We are in a difficult situation.** Our warehouse is almost empty.
Liam: What do you mean? Don't we have safety stock in the central hub?
Rachel: That stock is already allocated to regular orders for the next two weeks.
Liam: And what about current production? Can we increase the daily output?
Rachel: Both bottling lines are running at full capacity for the next twenty days.
Liam: But the Retail Mart promotion starts in exactly ten days.
Rachel: I know the date. That is why your promise puts us under huge pressure.
Liam: If we do not deliver, Retail Mart will cancel the entire promotion.
Rachel: And if we fail them, our penalty fees will be huge.
Rachel: Plus, we will damage our relationship with their leadership team for the whole year.
Liam: Rachel, **I understand your frustration.** I should have called you before confirming.
Rachel: Thank you for admitting that. It really helps when we work as a team.
Liam: My goal was just to protect our annual targets and secure volume.
Rachel: I understand your commercial goal, Liam, but physics and logistics have limits.
Liam: I know. Let's see what we can do to save this account.
Rachel: All right. Let's examine our inventory across all distribution centers.
Liam: How many total cases of iced tea do we have on hand right now?
Rachel: We have forty-five thousand cases across three hubs.
Liam: That sounds like enough to cover their thirty thousand extra cases.
Rachel: No, Liam. Thirty-five thousand of those cases are already booked for regional supermarket chains.
Liam: When are those regional deliveries scheduled to leave the warehouses?
Rachel: Most of them will ship between day twelve and day eighteen.
Liam: Day twelve is after the start of the Retail Mart campaign!
Rachel: Yes, but we cannot leave our other retail partners with empty shelves.
Liam: Of course not. But their sales velocity is much slower than Retail Mart.
Rachel: Are you suggesting we borrow stock from smaller clients?
Liam: If their delivery is on day eighteen, we can replace their stock in time.
Rachel: That is risky, Liam. Our factory schedule has zero buffer right now.
Liam: **Is there any way to** adjust the bottling schedule next week?

Rachel: Line two is currently scheduled to produce lemonade for four straight days.
Liam: Lemonade demand is lower in early June compared to iced tea.
Rachel: That is true, but lemonade stock is also running near safety levels.
Liam: Can we switch two of those days from lemonade to iced tea?
Rachel: A product changeover takes six hours on that line. We lose valuable time.
Liam: How many cases do we lose during a six-hour changeover?
Rachel: About three thousand cases of total production.
Liam: That is a painful loss, but missing this campaign would cost ten times more.
Rachel: The plant manager will not be happy with an unplanned changeover.
Liam: I can speak with the plant director if you need my support there.
Rachel: Do you have any suggestions? What would you tell the buyer right now?
Liam: I could call the buyer and propose delivering the extra volume in two shipments.
Rachel: That sounds much more realistic than sending everything in ten days.
Liam: We could deliver twenty thousand cases on day nine, before the launch.
Rachel: And the remaining ten thousand cases? When would they arrive at their depots?
Liam: We cannot change the past, but we can deliver the rest on day seventeen.
Rachel: Day seventeen would give our plant enough time to finish the lemonade run first.
Liam: Will twenty thousand extra cases cover their first promotional week?
Rachel: Yes, their initial order of sixty thousand cases plus twenty thousand is plenty.
Liam: That gives them eighty thousand cases for launch week. That is huge.
Rachel: Where do we take the twenty thousand cases from right now, though?
Liam: Can we borrow ten thousand cases from the regional distributors' reserve?
Rachel: We could borrow ten thousand from the northern hub. Their shipment leaves on day sixteen.
Liam: Could you look into the southern hub for another ten thousand cases?
Rachel: Let me check the southern warehouse inventory on my screen right now.
Liam: Take your time. Let's see what numbers show up there.
Rachel: Okay, the southern hub has twelve thousand unallocated cases of iced tea.
Liam: That is fantastic! Why were they not showing in the central system?
Rachel: They were held for quality inspection until this morning. They just got cleared.
Liam: That changes everything. That means we have ten thousand cases right there.
Rachel: Yes, but shipping from the south to Retail Mart costs slightly more in freight.
Liam: How much extra freight are we talking about per case?
Rachel: Roughly fifteen cents per case for express road transport.
Liam: My sales budget can cover that extra fifteen cents without any problem.
Rachel: Okay, so we borrow ten thousand from the north and take ten thousand from the south.
Liam: That gives us the twenty thousand cases needed for day nine.
Rachel: That covers phase one. Now, what about the remaining ten thousand cases?
Liam: What do you need from my side? Do you need overtime approval from management?
Rachel: If we run a Saturday shift next weekend, we can easily produce those cases.
Liam: How much will the Saturday overtime shift cost the company?
Rachel: About four thousand dollars for the full crew and plant utilities.
Liam: The gross margin on thirty thousand cases is over forty thousand dollars.
Rachel: So the business case clearly makes sense for management.

Liam: Yes, the return on investment is more than ten to one.

Rachel: I will submit the overtime request to the operations head this afternoon.

Liam: And I will explain the delivery plan to Retail Mart's head buyer.

Rachel: That would solve our problem. It keeps everyone happy and safe.

Liam: What if the buyer rejects the split delivery and demands everything on day nine?

Rachel: You must stand firm. Explain that full delivery on day nine is physically impossible.

Liam: I will present it as a benefit: fresher stock and less warehouse congestion for them.

Rachel: Good point. Buyers usually appreciate warehouse space management during peak summer season.

Liam: I will call him immediately after this meeting to lock in the split.

Rachel: Great. Once he confirms by email, I will book the northern and southern trucks.

Liam: Perfect. We should have the trucks booked by tomorrow morning.

Rachel: Liam, we saved the deal this time, but we cannot repeat this stress.

Liam: I completely agree. We came very close to a major operational crisis.

Rachel: Our teams need a clear process for extra volumes in the future.

Liam: Let's establish a clear rule for promo orders above ten thousand cases.

Rachel: How about this: any volume increase above fifteen percent requires your supply chain sign-off?

Liam: That sounds reasonable. We can do a quick check via chat or email first.

Rachel: A quick twenty-minute check will save us days of firefighting.

Liam: I will brief my entire sales team tomorrow. **I will make sure this does not happen again.**

Rachel: Thank you, Liam. I will also set up an automatic alert in our order system.

Liam: Excellent. Thank you for working through this with me, Rachel.

Rachel: You are welcome, Liam. Let's make this summer promo a big success.

Key phrases from this episode

We are in a difficult situation.	we have a serious problem to deal with — We are in a difficult situation because the main supplier cancelled today. — With fuel prices rising, we are in a difficult situation regarding delivery costs.
I understand your frustration.	I see why you are upset or annoyed — I understand your frustration with the delayed report, and I apologize. — The client called angry, but I said I understand your frustration.
Is there any way to	can we possibly find a method to — Is there any way to speed up customs clearance this week? — Is there any way to lower shipping costs on this route?
Do you have any suggestions?	what ideas do you propose? — We cannot meet this deadline. Do you have any suggestions? — Do you have any suggestions on how to improve client satisfaction?
We cannot change the past, but	focus on what to do now, not mistakes — We cannot change the past, but we can prevent this mistake tomorrow. — We cannot change the past, but we must protect current customer relationships.
Could you look into	please check or investigate this issue — Could you look into invoice errors before sending the monthly summary? — Could you look into transport availability for next Tuesday?
What do you need from my side?	how can I assist you specifically? — I want to help finish this project. What do you need from my side? — To finalize this deal quickly, what do you need from my side?
That would solve our problem.	this idea fixes our issue completely — If they accept partial shipment, that would solve our problem. — Finding local packaging supplies would solve our problem immediately.
Let's establish a clear rule for	we should agree on a standard procedure — Let's establish a clear rule for handling urgent client discounts. — Let's establish a clear rule for booking meeting rooms in advance.

I will make sure this does not happen again.	I take responsibility to prevent future repeats — I apologize for the delay. I will make sure this does not happen again. — We updated the software, and I will make sure this does not happen again.

Common mistakes

✗ Not: ~~We promised to the client thirty thousand extra cases.~~
✓ Better: **We promised the client thirty thousand extra cases.**
Promise takes a direct person object without the preposition 'to'.

✗ Not: ~~You should control stock levels before confirming orders.~~
✓ Better: **You should check stock levels before confirming orders.**
'Control' means manage or dominate. To inspect numbers, use 'check'.

✗ Not: ~~Can you tell me when will the shipment arrive?~~
✓ Better: **Can you tell me when the shipment will arrive?**
In indirect questions, the subject comes before the auxiliary verb.

✗ Not: ~~Our production output depends from available raw materials.~~
✓ Better: **Our production output depends on available raw materials.**
The verb 'depend' always takes the preposition 'on', never 'from'.

✗ Not: ~~She gave me an useful advice about factory scheduling.~~
✓ Better: **She gave me useful advice about factory scheduling.**
'Advice' is an uncountable noun in English and cannot take 'an'.

Quiz

1. Why is Rachel upset with Liam at the beginning?
A) He promised extra volume without checking stock.
B) He cancelled an important client meeting.
C) He lost the contract with Retail Mart.

2. How many extra cases did Retail Mart request for the promo?
A) Ten thousand cases
B) Twenty thousand cases
C) Thirty thousand cases

3. How do Liam and Rachel agree to deliver the extra volume?
A) Twenty thousand now, and ten thousand one week later
B) Deliver all thirty thousand cases on day nine
C) Cancel smaller client orders and deliver everything today

4. How will the factory produce the second batch of ten thousand cases?
A) By closing the lemonade line permanently
B) By running an overtime Saturday shift
C) By outsourcing production to a competitor

5. What internal rule do Liam and Rachel agree to implement for the future?
A) Volume increases over fifteen percent require supply chain sign-off.
B) Sales reps cannot talk directly to large supermarket buyers.
C) Factories will hold fifty percent of goods as safety stock.

Answers: 1-A 2-C 3-A 4-B 5-A

Dialogue voices are AI-generated. Every episode is built on a real, anonymized case from the host's 15+ years in FMCG and key account management.